Your Family's Part of the Plan

What to summarize, talk over and write down, in order, before a professional reviews it.

The goal: your family can hand a professional one dated set of pages showing where things stand with Mom today, what she has said she wants, what you're keeping an eye on, and which questions are still open.

There's no clock on this. Share the list, put a name next to each action and a date that suits your family, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write a short note on how Mom is managing today: what she does on her own, and where someone already lends a hand. Date it.			
2. Write down what Mom or her doctor has said about help she may need later, in their words.			
3. Summarize her finances on one page in round numbers: what comes in, what she has, what she owes, and whose name each is in as far as the paperwork shows.			
4. Write down what you've read or been told about Medicaid so far, and who said it. Where two people disagree, write both.			
5. List the legal documents you know she has, such as her will, and her insurance policies, with where each is kept and the date on it.			
6. Agree which family members take part in planning, and set a time to talk with Mom.			
7. Ask Mom what she'd want if she needed more help, and who she'd want handling money matters and healthcare decisions if she couldn't. Write down what she says.			
8. List the things your family has thought about doing. Mark anything that involves moving, gifting or retitling money or property, creating or changing a legal document, or buying or cancelling insurance “ask first,” and change nothing.			
9. Write down what your family is keeping an eye on, and the changes you've said would make you pick this up again.			
10. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: the family, your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial or insurance professional, a tax professional, or “not sure.”			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
11. Put the pages in one folder, and tell the family members taking part where it is.			

You're done when

Where things stand today, what Mom has said she wants, what you're keeping an eye on, what would make you pick this up again and your open questions are all written down and dated, each question with a name beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list: sorting what can be addressed now from what should wait, saying whether anything stands in the way, the legal and financial questions, and the written roadmap itself. Those come out of the review with your Medicaid planner and the appropriate licensed professionals, and they aren't the family's to do alone.

If a step stalls

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If two people have told you different things, write down both and who said each. Sorting them out belongs to the review.
- If Mom isn't ready to talk about part of it, write that it's open and come back to it another day.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't determine Medicaid eligibility, say what should be done now or what can wait, recommend a legal or financial step, or stand in for the professional review it prepares you for, and it isn't legal, tax or financial advice. Rules vary by state; bring those questions to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You've put your family's part in order. The planning interview is the next step: answer its questions about your family's situation and it gives you a free planning report you can bring, with these pages, to your Medicaid planner.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›